

Arizona State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Fringe-bowl / middle-to-lower Power 4 quality with legitimate defensive upside but substantial QB, OL and secondary rebuild risk.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 51
Returning production	51% (No. 73) overall · Off. 53% (No. 73) · Def. 49% (No. 79)
Primer power rating	+5.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.8 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ - Worse and much less stable than the 8-5 2025 team because the QB, top WR, first-round OT and large parts of the defense must be replaced.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: RB Kyson Brown and WR Omarion Miller lead an offense with an unresolved QB Cutter Boley/QB Mikey Keene competition behind a rebuilt line. DT C.J. Fite and LB Owen Long anchor DC Brian Ward's reworked defense.

Bottom line: Arizona State has enough disruption and skill talent to reach a bowl, but replacing QB Sam Leavitt, WR Jordyn Tyson, OT Max Iheanachor and much of the defense makes six wins a midpoint rather than a floor.

Beats expectations if: QB Cutter Boley or QB Mikey Keene becomes an efficient starter, the new OL settles quickly, WR Omarion Miller replaces enough of WR Jordyn Tyson's value, and DC Brian Ward preserves the defense's havoc/explosive-prevention identity.

Disappoints if: QB uncertainty and protection problems amplify the poor 2025 success-rate/third-down profile, TE Khamari Anderson's absence weakens the middle, and the rebuilt secondary cannot replace its departures.

Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB question:** QB Cutter Boley vs. QB Mikey Keene remains unresolved; Boley had the stronger late first-team signal, but no starter is declared.
- 2 **Returning production:** Returning production is only 51% overall (No. 73) and 49% on defense (No. 79), matching the heavy turnover.
- 3 **★ WR Omarion Miller:** WR Omarion Miller and DT C.J. Fite are both Big 12 preseason first-team selections; DT Fite also carries Nagurski and Outland recognition.
- 4 **Quarterback:** The offense loses QB Sam Leavitt, first-round WR Jordyn Tyson and first-round OT Max Iheanachor, making the rebuild high leverage.
- 5 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense ranked No. 14 in havoc and No. 12 in explosive prevention, giving DC Brian Ward a clear identity to preserve.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (6-3 Big 12)	● Good
Scoring	25.8 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	417.3 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	193.6 YPG · 5.1 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	6.76 YPA · 20 TD / 9 INT	● Below average
Third downs	33.3%	● Poor
Scoring defense	24.5 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	357.5 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	124.0 YPG · 3.6 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	233.5 YPG · 6.61 YPA · 20 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Arizona State moved the ball better than it finished drives: total offense ranked No. 30 and rushing No. 27, but scoring was No. 81 and third downs No. 120. The defense ranked No. 65 in scoring and No. 31 against the run.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.56 · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.071 · No. 41	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	40.4% · No. 97	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	13.4% · No. 36	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	16.5% · No. 96	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+2.67 · No. 39	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.105 · No. 26	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	39.7% · No. 43	● Good / above average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	8.8% · No. 12	● Elite
Havoc created	18.5% · No. 14	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Arizona State’s 2025 offense generated yardage and explosiveness, but poor success rate, third downs and havoc allowed limited scoring consistency.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / increased offensive involvement	Kenny Dillingham - Returning HC; explicitly more hands-on with offense in 2026	● ↔ Kenny Dillingham returns with a more hands-on offensive role, increasing his direct influence on that unit.
OC	Marcus Arroyo - Returning OC; live-call division with Dillingham unresolved	● ↔ Marcus Arroyo returns, but the live-call division with Dillingham remains unresolved.
DC	Brian Ward - Returning DC / scheme owner; in-game signal-caller unresolved	● ↔ Brian Ward keeps the defensive system intact, though the in-game signal-caller remains unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Cutter Boley	Kentucky	● ↔ A legitimate co-finalist with the strongest late first-team signal.
◆ QB Mikey Keene	Michigan	● ↔ Keeps veteran competition in the room.
◆ WR Omarion Miller	Colorado	● ↑ Big 12 first-team/Biletnikoff recognition gives ASU a credible primary target after WR Jordyn Tyson's departure.
◆ OL Tana Alo-Tupuola	Georgia Tech	● ↔ Took late-camp first-team center reps in a rebuilt line.

Out	To	Loss
QB Sam Leavitt	LSU	● ↓ The 2025 quarterback leaves for LSU.
WR Jordyn Tyson	NFL (New Orleans), Round 1, No. 8	● ↓ The No. 8 overall draft pick leaves a premium receiving role that even a strong transfer addition may not fully replace.
OT Max Iheanachor	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 1, No. 21	● ↓ First-round tackle talent departs from a line relying on a new late-camp first unit.
OT Josh Atkins	Missouri	● ↓ A 2025 high-snap transfer departure adds to the line rebuild.
RB Raleek Brown	Texas	● ↔ A material 2025 back departs.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Clear downgrade and major volatility relative to 2025; WR Miller and the returning RB room soften the losses.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Owen Long	Colorado State	● ↑ Butkus recognition and a first-team leadership role make him a high-leverage addition.
◆ CB Ashton Stamps	LSU	● ↔ LSU transfer immediately appears with the late-camp first unit in a heavily rebuilt secondary.
◆ S Lyrik Rawls	Kansas	● ↔ Kansas transfer holds a late-camp first-team safety role and helps replace multiple departures.
◆ DE Jalen Thompson	Michigan State	● ↔ Michigan State transfer adds first-unit edge experience to a front replacing several veteran contributors.

Out	To	Loss
CB Keith Abney II	NFL (Detroit), Round 5, No. 157	● ↓ A drafted corner leaves a secondary that also lost transfer and pro-football contributors.
LB Keyshaun Elliott	NFL (Chicago), Round 5, No. 166	● ↓ Drafted LB production leaves a unit now leaning on LB Owen Long and LB Martell Hughes.
CB Javan Robinson	Wisconsin	● ↓ One of the four outgoing transfers above 150 2025 snaps leaves for Wisconsin.
S Xavion Alford	NFL (Tampa Bay), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A safety departure to the NFL contributes to the heavy back-end turnover.
EDGE Prince Dorbah	NFL (Buffalo), undrafted free agent	● ↓ An edge departure to the NFL raises the replacement burden around DT C.J. Fite.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Likely downgrade in stability even if the scheme remains effective; DT Fite and LB Long give the unit anchors.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	The safest inherited identity is run-oriented production with RB Kyson Brown.	The 2025 offense generated top-30 total and rushing yardage.	The same 2025 offense ranked No. 97 in success rate and No. 120 on third downs, and now replaces its QB and much of the line.
Defense	Brian Ward's returning defense is best understood through disruption.	DT C.J. Fite and LB Owen Long anchor a unit whose 2025 havoc-created rank was No. 14 and explosive-play prevention No. 12.	The surrounding front and secondary have been heavily rebuilt after transfer, draft and post-draft professional departures.
Special teams	Both specialist jobs carry transition risk.	Nick McLarty had the strongest late punting signal.	Kicker remains open and SP+ special teams ranks No. 129.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Low	QB Cutter Boley and QB Mikey Keene remain in an unresolved competition replacing QB Sam Leavitt.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Kyson Brown gives the offense its clearest returning skill anchor.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium	WR Omarion Miller adds high-end talent, but first-round WR Jordyn Tyson's production is gone.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Khamari Anderson projects as the top option, but early-season availability remains unresolved.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	First-round OT Max Iheanachor is gone, and the rebuilt line has no settled final five.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium	DT C.J. Fite anchors a disruptive front replacing EDGE Prince Dorbah and other veterans.
LB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	LB Owen Long is a strong addition, but multiple veteran LBs departed.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Ashton Stamps and S Lyrik Rawls join a secondary replacing extensive veteran production.
Special teams	● C	● ↓	Low	P Nick McLarty leads the punter race, kicker is open, and SP+ ranks the unit No. 129.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Kenny Dillingham, OC Marcus Arroyo and DC Brian Ward return; exact live-call duties remain unresolved.
Overall	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	Fringe-bowl quality with defensive upside, but QB, OL and secondary rebuild risk keeps the floor low.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Omarion Miller (TR: Colorado)	WR	● High-end conference starter / primary target projection	Big 12 preseason first team · Biletnikoff Award	Clearest candidate to replace WR Jordyn Tyson's headline receiving role.
C.J. Fite	DT	● High-end conference starter / defensive centerpiece	Big 12 preseason first team · Bronko Nagurski Trophy · Outland Trophy	The best-established defender on a rebuilt unit.
◆ Owen Long (TR: Colorado State)	LB	● High-end conference starter / defensive leader	Butkus Award	Butkus-recognized stabilizer in a rebuilt front seven.
◆ Cutter Boley (TR: Kentucky)	QB	● Unproven starter candidate / competition leader	-	Held the stronger late first-team signal, but he has not been named the starter.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Mikey Keene (TR: Michigan)	QB	● Veteran competition finalist	-	Remains one of the two separated finalists; his presence keeps the position competitive.
Kyson Brown	RB	● Solid-to-high-end conference starter projection	-	Returning lead/major back in the unit.
Khamari Anderson	TE	● Starting-caliber return / availability watch	-	Projects as the top tight end when available.
◆ Ashton Stamps (TR: LSU)	CB	● Transfer starter projection	-	Late-camp first-unit CB in a secondary needing immediate replacement value.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderately hard and highly swing-game driven; two major road underdog spots are balanced by a large cluster of games near Arizona State's own rating.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · SP+ SOS No. 28
Hardest stretch	at Texas Tech -> Kansas State -> at BYU
Swing games	Kansas (neutral), Baylor, Kansas State, Colorado, at UCF, Oklahoma State, at Arizona
Advantage	A bye follows the neutral Kansas game, and the home Hawaii game comes immediately before the trip to Texas Tech.
Expected	5.8 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 8-5 2025 record can make Arizona State look sturdier than a No. 51 SP+ team with 51% returning production. The most bankable positive is Kenny Dillingham's offensive/QB development, so the upside case is primarily a coaching bet rather than a continuity bet.
Back them when	Catching points against an opponent with protection/turnover vulnerabilities.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a meaningful premium before the QB and OL prove they can avoid the 2025 success-rate/third-down problems.
Key monitor	starting QB and snap plan, official OL five, TE Khamari Anderson availability, secondary rotation, kicker winner, exact offensive live-call division
Week 1 baseline	vs. Morgan State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Arizona State -41.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Arizona State still has defensive disruption and enough skill talent to reach a bowl, but only 51% of production returns and the roster replaces QB Sam Leavitt, WR Jordyn Tyson and OT Max Iheanachor. The QB and OL rebuilds create the widest offensive variance.

Six wins is a reasonable midpoint. The upside requires a clear QB winner and preservation of DC Brian Ward's havoc/explosive-prevention identity; the downside grows quickly if protection and secondary turnover become weekly problems.

About this primer

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